

Indochina into the 21st Century

Indochina entered the 21st century with outmoded political systems, causing social and economic stagnation, while their Asian neighbors embraced modernization. Vietnam has since started down this path, but Cambodia and Laos still lag far behind.

◀◀ BEFORE

Indochina saw almost constant war for nearly 50 years, from World War II until the 1990s.

A TROUBLED PAST

The struggle to emerge from their **colonization** by the French led the freedom fighters of Indochina to adopt a communist ideology, which in turn brought the liberation movements into **conflict with the United States**.

LEGACY OF CONFLICT

The resulting warfare left a legacy of economic, political, and humanitarian **damage to Vietnam** and its neighbors, presenting a huge challenge for its people to overcome as they entered the new century.

With a population of more than 96 million, according to the 2019 census, Vietnam is the 16th most populous country in the world, and it is one of only five remaining single-party communist countries in existence. It now enjoys diplomatic relations with most of the world and is a member of 49 international organizations, including the United Nations (UN), Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), and the Non-Aligned Movement, as well as 396 nongovernmental organizations. The establishment of diplomatic relations with the US in 1995 opened doors, and the two have engaged in both military exchanges and joint exercises.

In spite of this apparent progress, however, Amnesty International continues to cite severe restrictions on freedom of speech and assembly in Vietnam, the persecution of dissidents, state control over the media and judiciary, and harsh treatment of minorities.